

Committee: Human Rights Council

Topic: Rebuilding Human Rights Frameworks After Global Disruption Ex: Displacement, Survival, and the Ethics of Humanitarian Protection.

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Introduction

The International Human Rights system was created after the Second World War, where states agreed through documents such as the Universal Declaration of Human Rights (1948) and the Refugee Convention (1951) that people fleeing danger deserve protection. Currently this system is under more pressure than at any point it has been in its history. Wars in Sudan, Ukraine, Gaza, and Myanmar, climate-caused disasters, economic collapse, and the aftereffects of the COVID-19 pandemic have helped push forced displacement to extreme levels: an example of this being by the end of 2024, UNHCR counted 123.2 million forcibly displaced people, making up roughly 1 in every 67 people on Earth. At the same time, humanitarian funding was destroyed in 2025, as many countries tightened their borders, and rules meant to protect civilians and aid workers are being openly ignored by many people.

Many ethical questions rise upon this issue such as: When resources are limited, who gets protected first? Can states restrict asylum in the name of their own security or “survival”? And how can humanitarian protection remain neutral and principled in a world where aid is mostly used for political reasons between states? The Human Rights Council must consider how to rebuild these frameworks that are strong enough to survive the next global disruption.

Key Words

Forced Displacement - The movement of people who have been forced or obliged to leave their homes due to conflict, persecution, violence, human rights violations, or disasters.

Refugee - A person who has crossed an international border because of a well-founded fear of persecution based on race, religion, nationality, political opinion, or membership of a particular social group (1951 Refugee Convention).

Internally Displaced Person (IDP) - a person forced to flee their home who remains within the borders of their own country; therefore, is not legally a refugee.

Asylum seeker - a person forced to flee their home who remains within the borders of their own country, and therefore is not legally a refugee.

Non-refoulement - the core principle of refugee and human rights law that forbids a state from returning a person to a country where they would face persecution, torture, or other serious harm.

Humanitarian principles - the four principles guiding humanitarian action: humanity, neutrality, impartiality, and independence.

Humanitarian protection - activities aimed at ensuring the full respect of the rights of individuals affected by crises, not only providing food and shelter but also keeping people safe from violence, exploitation, and abuse.

Pushback - the practice of forcing migrants or asylum seekers back across a border without assessing their individual protection needs, often violating non-refoulement.

Externalisation - when a state moves its border control or asylum processing to another country (for example, through offshore processing deals)

Burden-sharing (responsibility-sharing) - the idea that the responsibility for hosting and supporting refugees should be shared fairly among states rather than falling mostly on neighbouring countries.

Climate displacement - displacement caused by sudden disasters (floods, storms) or slow-onset environmental change (drought, sea-level rise).

Durable solutions - the three long-term outcomes for refugees: voluntary return home, local integration in the host country, or resettlement to a third country.

Triage (humanitarian) - the process of prioritising who receives aid when resources are not enough to help everyone in need.

General Overview

Forced displacement amongst many has grown largely over the past decade. According to the UNHCR, the number of forcibly displaced people rose to 123.3 million by the end of 2024, including 73.5 million internally displaced people, 42.7 million refugees and 8.4 million asylum seekers. The number of IDPS alone has doubled in ten years. Sudan is now the world's largest displacement crisis with over 14 million people forced away from their homes, followed by Syria, Afghanistan, and Ukraine. UNHCR's 2025 Global Trends report that was published in June 2026, recorded a slight fall to 117.8 million by the end of 2025, mostly because 14.7 million people returned home. However, UNHCR warned that many of these returns to home, especially of Afghans expelled from Iran and Pakistan, were most likely involuntary, which raises serious questions about whether non-refoulement is being respected currently in our world. Climate change adds a further layer to this. The Internal Displacement Monitoring Centre (IDMC) issued a record of 83.4 million people living in internal displacement at the end of 2024, with disasters alone causing over 45 million new displacements that year.

Unfortunately, the existing legal framework was not designed for the scale or these causes. The 1951 Refugee Convention protects people fleeing persecution, but not people fleeing climate disasters, economic collapse, or generalized violence in their country. IDPs, who make up the majority of the displaced, have no binding International treaty at all; only the non-binding Guiding Principles on Internal Displacement (1998) and the regional Kampala Convention in Africa are binding. However, some progress has been made through human rights law, such as *Teitiota v. New Zealand* (2020), in which the UN Human Rights Committee stated that states may not return people to places where climate change threatens their right to life, and in July 2025 the International Court of Justice issued an advisory opinion confirming that states have legal obligations regarding climate change in their own state. Still, large gaps remain, and displaced people often fall between different legal categories.

At the same time, the political will to protect displaced people is weakening. In early 2025, sudden cuts to foreign aid by major donors, most notably the United States, caused what the UN called the "cruel math of aid cuts." The 2025 Global humanitarian overview originally asked for \$44 billion to help 178.7 million people, but by June 2025 the UN was forced to "hyper prioritise" its appeal to \$29.1 billion, targeting only 114.4 million of the nearly 300 million people in need of help. By then, only \$5.5 billion had been received. Meanwhile, many states have made asylum harder to access, such as through pushbacks at land and sea borders, offshore processing agreements (such as the Italy-Albania protocol), suspension of refugee settlement programs, and the EU pact on Migration and Asylum, which entered into use in June 2026 and introduces faster border procedures that human rights groups fear may reduce safeguards.

Many supporters argue these measures help States manage migration in an orderly way, helping them protect their own security and public services.

These pressures create real ethical dilemmas in humanitarian protection. When there is not enough funding, aid agencies must choose which crisis and which people to prioritize, impacting who survives. Humanitarian workers themselves are increasingly at risk in these issues: an example of this is in the year 2024, which was the deadliest year on record for Aid workers, with 383 killed, nearly half of them in Gaza. Access to civilians is frequently restricted or used as a weapon of war, as seen in Sudan and Gaza. There's also a debate about whether each should stay strictly neutral, or whether agencies should speak out against the states and groups responsible for the displacement of many groups of people. The central challenge for the Human Rights Council is therefore how to rebuild a protection framework that closes these legal gaps, is fairly funded and shared among states, and still upholds the dignity and rights of every displaced person, even in times of crisis.

Major Parties Involved

UNHCR (UN Refugee Agency) - the main UN body which is responsible for protecting refugees, stateless people, and (increasingly) IDPs; looks over the Refugee Convention.

OHCHR and the Human Rights Council - monitor human rights violations against displaced people, and appoint Special Rapporteurs (e.g. on the human rights of migrants and of IDPs).

OCHA and IOM - OCHA monitors the global humanitarian response and funding appeals; IOM (International Organization for Migration) supports migrants and tracks displacement.

ICRC (International Committee of the Red Cross) - the one that guards international humanitarian law and a key neutral actor in conflict zones.

Major countries of origin - Sudan, Syria, Afghanistan, Ukraine, Venezuela, Myanmar, South Sudan, the Democratic Republic of the Congo, Palestine (Gaza).

Major host countries - Türkiye, Iran, Colombia, Germany, Uganda, Pakistan, Chad, Egypt, Poland; around two-thirds of refugees are located in low- and middle-income countries neighbouring the one they left originally.

Major donor states - the United States, Germany, the European Union, the United Kingdom and Japan; lack of support from these states in 2025 impacted the humanitarian system.

The European Union - through the Pact on Migration and Asylum and externalisation agreements with countries like Tunisia, Libya, Türkiye and Albania.

Climate-vulnerable states - small island states such as Tuvalu and Kiribati, and countries in the Sahel and South Asia, who vouch for recognition of climate displacement.

NGOs - Norwegian Refugee Council (NRC), Médecins Sans Frontières (MSF), Amnesty International, Human Rights Watch, who deliver aid and document violations.

Timeline of Relevant Events

Year	Event
1948	The Universal Declaration of Human Rights is created; Article 14 recognises the right to seek asylum
1949	The four Geneva Conventions impose the rules protecting civilians and humanitarian workers during armed conflict
1950	UNHCR is created to help people displaced by the Second World War
1951	The Refugee Convention defines who is a refugee and establishes non-refoulement
1967	The Protocol Relating to the Status of Refugees removes the Convention's geographic and time limits, making it universal to all
1998	The Guiding Principles on Internal Displacement are presented to the UN, the first international standard for IDPs
2006	The Human Rights Council is established, replacing the Commission on Human Rights
2009	The African Union adopts the Kampala Convention, the first binding regional treaty on IDPs (in force 2012)
2015	Over one million people reach Europe, mostly fleeing Syria, Afghanistan and Iraq, in what became known as the "refugee crisis"
2016	The New York Declaration for Refugees and Migrants is adopted by the UN General Assembly
2018	The Global Compact on Refugees and the Global Compact for Migration are adopted
2020	The COVID-19 pandemic leads to widespread border closures; the Human Rights Committee issues its <i>Teitiota v. New Zealand</i> decision on climate displacement

Relevant Documents

[The 1951 Refugee Convention and its 1967 Protocol](#)

The key legal document that defines who is a refugee, their rights, and the obligation of non-refoulement

[New York Declaration for Refugees and Migrants](#) (UN General Assembly Resolution 71/1)

A 2016 commitment by all UN member states to protect the rights of refugees and migrants and share responsibility more fairly, which led to the Global Compacts

[The Global Compact on Refugees](#) (2018) and the Global Refugee Forum 2023

A non-binding system for fairer responsibility-sharing, easing pressure on host countries helping expand long lasting solutions

[Guiding Principles on Internal Displacement](#) (1998)

The main international process setting out the rights of IDPs and the duties of states towards them

[Kampala Convention](#) (African Union, 2009)

The world's only legally binding regional treaty on the protection of internally displaced people

[Human Rights Committee decision in Teitiotia v. New Zealand](#) (2020)

A landmark decision stating that states cannot return people to places where climate change puts their lives at serious risk

[Global Humanitarian Overview 2025: The Cruel Math of Aid Cuts](#) (OCHA, June 2025)

Explains how funding cuts forced the UN to prioritise only the most life-threatening needs, and the human cost of doing so

Possible Solutions

Although the challenges facing displaced people are big, delegates may consider several possible solutions:

1. Closing the legal protection gaps for IDPs and climate-displaced people

The council can suggest states to create National laws based on the Guiding Principles, which promote regional treaties similar to the Kampala Convention and other regions, and recognize climate displacement in human rights promises such as the right to life. Delegates should consider if a new international tool is realistic to use or if strengthening already existing laws is more achievable and could be applied.

2. Creating fairer and more predictable responsibility-sharing and funding

Poorer neighboring countries are the ones holding the most refugees, while humanitarian funding depends on it's amount of donors. In the solutions, it could include pooled or multi-year funding mechanisms, which involve Banks and the private sector, expanding the resettlement places and safer legal pathways (such as labour mobility, family reunification, and student visas), and ensuring that the pledges made at the global Refugee Forum are actually delivered.

3. *Strengthening monitoring and accountability for violations of non-refoulement*
Independent border monitoring methods, regular reporting to the Human Rights Council, and clear human rights safeguards in any objectification of processing agreements could help ensure that states' migration policies do not violate international law. Returns of people should be assessed to ensure they are truly voluntary, safe, and dignified reasons for moving.

4. *Protecting humanitarian workers and principled humanitarian access*
The Council could call for stronger accountability for attacks on aid workers, support inquiries into the blocking of aid, and create ethical guidelines for how aid is prioritized when resources are limited, so that decisions about who receives help remains clear, transparent, neutral, and based on need, rather than on political interest.

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